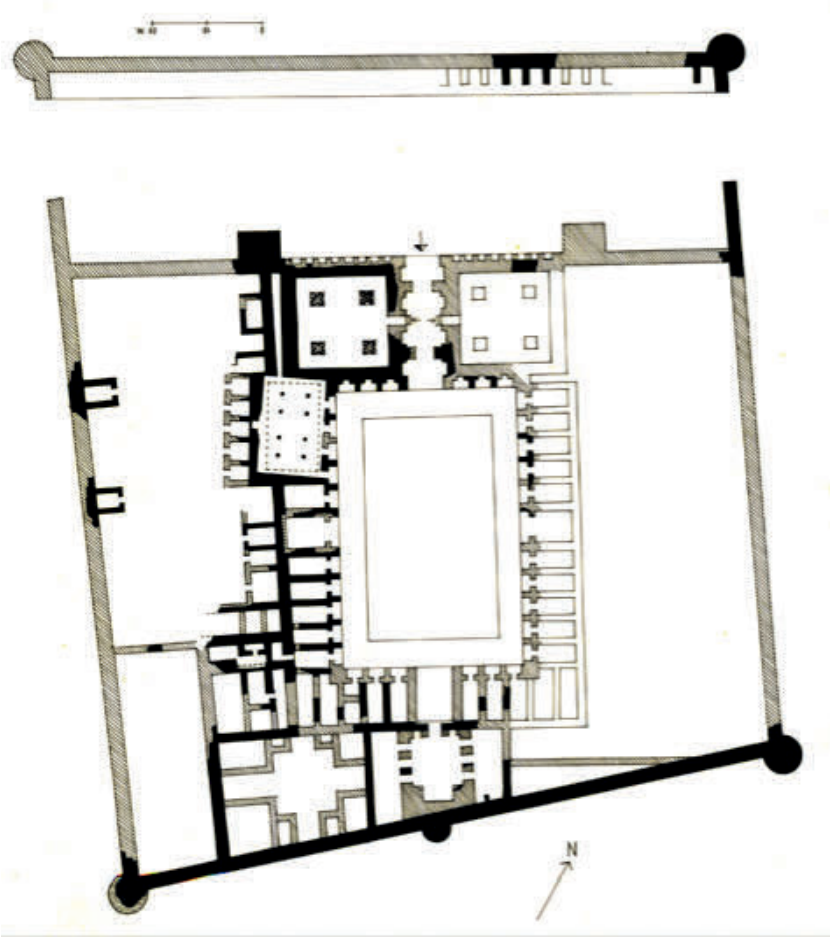


Figure 5.2 *Ghazna, central palace, plan of excavated areas and hypothetical reconstructions. After Giunta 2020: fig. 2.*

bands still *in situ* during the Italian excavations of the 1960s (Figure 5.6): the chunky, bold letters with decorative stem terminals standing out against a background of small, triangular solids and voids – emphasized further by being painted. Moreover, these terracotta epigraphic bands formed a stark, formal contrast to the refined marble dado below (Figures 5.6 and 5.7), which had consisted of rectangular panels carrying arabesques and floral motifs bordered by a continuous horizontal band of elegant floriated Kufic or *naskh*[25] (cf. below). Thus far, then, analyses of the painted terracotta epigraphic fragments from Ghazna's central palace point to very marked renovations of at least parts of the main courtyard's façade, probably executed during the reign of Mu'izz al-Din (r. at Ghazna AH 568–602/1173–1206 CE) and perhaps even shortly after the Shansabani conquest of the city.

Indeed, Mu'izz al-Din's notable renovations of the Ghazna palace